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The Soul of an Octopus Review

The Soul of an Octopus... is a mixture between subjective experiences and objective recordings with various aquatic life the author, Sy Montgomery, gathered on multiple visits to the New England Aquarium. What makes this book interesting to me is how she uses her extensive knowledge of human neurology coupled with outside research on the creatures she observes, to explain her experiences throughout the book. I don't really agree with this path of logic as I find this method to be equivalent to using a correlation study as a model of prediction. Correlation studies are designed to model relationships between scenarios, and then after they're established, we make claims regarding causality. Just because we know the systems and methods behind the front of the creature does not mean we can apply it to explain the *why's* associated with one instance of behavior. For example, I found Montgomery's explanation about Octavia pulling her harder than Athena as a difference in her "taste" (pain/estrogen) to be quite farfetched. Though she *could* be right, much like how a correlation study *could* explain causation, I believe there are many other factors that are overlooked. As we know, confounding factors are present in every scenario of math and science, to think otherwise would be a major flaw. Overlooking concepts as simple as Octavia not knowing how to scale her strength to humans as well as Athena could, shrouds believability no matter how extensive the research or observation is. I can't speak for any of my peers that also read the novel, but I personally feel

that the best way to convince someone that a nonintuitive observation is the right one, is by having some mention of where a simple explanation might fall.

Though I am critical of a few explanations Montgomery poses, it is important to point out that nowhere in the book does she try to *prove* why she thinks her reasoning is the right way to think about a behavior than another view. Upon reading the first two sections, I thought this was going to be an argumentative novel about why we should acknowledge the octopus as a conscious species. Despite posing personal anecdotes that clearly suggest she believes they are conscious beings, there is truly no reasonable argument posed to validate it objectively. She even acknowledges this very early in the novel when she references her connection to Athena and relates it to the very same Thomas Nagel paper we read as a class, "What it's like to be a bat." By doing this, she is basically asserting that her observations are open to interpretation from any side of an argument. In other words, her purpose for writing this novel was to provide her own observations and propose intellectually why she *thinks* the creatures behaved a certain way, not why she *knows*. Once the reader can get past this hurdle by treating her experiences as what they are instead of trying to argue the objectiveness in each one, the reader can truly appreciate all the hard work Montgomery put into writing this novel. She acknowledges the intense criticism famous scientist Jane Goodall feared when contemplating whether to publish some of her observations that she thought may result from projecting her human emotion onto the chimpanzees' actions, yet Montgomery still decides that including her own observations with injected human emotion was necessary for her novel. On a much broader sense, we may even consider the true value of her subjective observations when compared to that of an objective observation, or even argue that a true objective observation does not exist.

When considering the value of her experiences, there are two main points we can look into: target audience and comparative thinking. The reason I'm choosing these two concepts as points of emphasis is because both drastically affect how she decides to word the novel. Her wording is what drives our perception of her experiences, and that ultimately drives what our takeaway is going to be. Contingent upon her wording, people from different scientific backgrounds are going to have different levels of understanding when she talks about the octopus. If she chooses to lean heavily into the breakdown of the octopuses' neurology, the book is going to have a stronger appeal towards those interested in neuro. If she chooses to focus on the octopuses' behavior and anatomy, the book is going to have a stronger appeal towards those interested in marine biology. In both scenarios, the novel would most likely come out as an extended documentary rather than the mixture between experience and research we observe. To get a better understanding of why she went with this approach rather than the latter, I felt it was necessary to do a brief amount of research on Sy Montgomery's writing history. Here we can build at least the foundation of who her target audience *might* be, and from there we can analyze particular instances of comparative thinking.

We can easily find that Sy Montgomery has two true passions: writing and animals. From her personal website, we can gather that she is a natural storyteller. Along with her 28 books that she's published, aimed for both adults and children, she travels to various locations around the world to tell some of her fascinating stories and give people the chance to have open discussions. One thing is clear, she wants to project her point of view of these experiences in a way that they can have lasting effects on a wide audience. She wants others to share her passion about animals and tries to the best of her ability to be the voice of the unheard. *The*

Soul of an Octopus... is no different. In this novel, Montgomery extends, as I see it, minor interactions with the aquatic life by injecting her human emotion into each passage. She does this to get the reader to project their own emotion onto her own experiences, or in other words, to make personal connections. Now, to relate this back to the two main points I wanted to address earlier, this means that Montgomery has *no* specific target audience. The only requirements she expects the reader to have are an interest in octopuses/animals and an open mind. Her expectations aren't that the reader should have a full understanding of either the octopus or neurology. She wants people from all backgrounds to enjoy her novel and have some valued takeaway by the end of reading it. Knowing the wide range of people that would be reading her novel, she needed to be able to generalize foreign topics into something that most people could understand. This is where comparative thinking factors in.

The most fundamental way of understanding a new topic is by making a connection to something we already know. It does not need to be a *realistic* comparison, but rather something related in even the broadest sense. Montgomery does this many times throughout her novel. The most effective passages related a behavior she had either witnessed or learned about to a humanized experience. The easiest example to cite would be her description of Athena passing the fish she was fed, sucker to sucker, in a conveyer belt like fashion so she could savor the meal and the taste. No matter if Athena was truly savoring her meal, the reader can still make the connection that the octopus' suckers were functioning as both taste buds and a grip. Though she often states researched facts to support her experience, she wants us to *see* what's happening while also *understanding* what's happening. This is where the novel gets its true value. It is her descriptive experiences that serve as the vehicle for our takeaway while the

neurology component is used to rationalize her *own* observations of the experience. Us as readers are at liberty to interpret them in any way we choose to, so long that we understand there *is* a choice. This goes hand-in-hand with Thomas Nagel's argument. We can have the most profound knowledge of an organism, but we will never have a proven way of knowing the motivation behind behavior. This doubt is what allows any interpretation of her experiences to be valid as long as *reasonable* support is added. Some, like Montgomery, may use neurology. Others, like myself, may use environmental factors. The point is, her experiences are the most valuable piece of the novel and the research she does to explain each one serves as a way to get the reader to start thinking about the motivation behind behavior (i.e. consciousness).

As for my own personal takeaway, I went into the novel having a pretty strong stance on consciousness. Referring to any organism as a *conscious species* is setting yourself up for failure. When judging the consciousness of a species, the end goal is to determine if it has self-awareness. In my eyes, because there's no definitive way to prove it, it's a loaded question. However, I think that if we and built an intelligence scale that assigned points based on scenario-based research, we could guestimate a line where consciousness *could* lie. Please excuse this thought if such a scale already exists, this just serves to explain my stance prior to reading the novel. After reading the novel, I really didn't know what to think. I definitely had a newly found appreciation for the octopus and its intelligence, but I was unsure of what to think of its consciousness. Is withholding conclusions based on Nagel's argument truly justified or are we holding ourselves to an unachievable and unrealistic standard? Is it even worth spending time trying to understand consciousness in other species? What would be *our* benefit from

labeling a species as conscious? With that, I will leave it open to discussion after my in-class presentation.

Works Cited

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